Chicken Soup Goes Hawaiian

What the world needs now is some emotional *Chicken Soup*, Hawaiian style. Robin Stephens Rohr and a remarkable cast of contributors are serving it up this week

By DON CHAPMAN

It makes you wonder … about fate and karma and the gods. What was it six years ago that gave Robin Stephens Rohr the big idea to create a local-style version of the classic series *Chicken Soup for the Soul*? And how is it that after six years of touch-and-go and not knowing until last July that her dream would become a reality, and now just as America is stepping deep into war, facing a foggy future and needing words of wisdom, *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* is at last seeing the light of day?

"We certainly didn't plan it this way," Rohr says. "It just happened."

It makes you wonder … because if ever there was a time for food or words — or anything else — that bring comfort and healing, the spring of 2003 gets our vote.

"It's been scientifically proven by the Mayo Clinic that chicken soup is high in vitamins and minerals and fights cold symptoms," Rohr says. "A good story is nourishing in the same way that this legendary broth is. A good story can comfort, uplift, inspire and give you strength and hope. A story like that, well told, true and straight from the heart, is so delicious. It really does nourish the soul."

She adds that the stories in the book, due in local book stores by the end of this week, are "juicy." The way she says it — like a sunny picnic at Ala Moana Park, not a gossip column item — the image that comes to mind is more Kahuku watermelon juice running down her grin than chicken soup.

Nathalie Walker photo

Nalani Olds (right) says meeting Robin Rohr was 'like meeting a long-lost sister'

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Photo courtesy of the Rohrs

When Clint Eastwood and wife Dina provided a chapter, it made Rohr's day. That's husband Tom to the left

As has been written before in these pages, the Hawaiian concept of aloha lights the way to peace on Earth and understanding among us humanoids. So too does the way that seemingly every race on Earth and a major bunch of the religions share these islands, respecting and even celebrating their neighbors' cultures.

Says Rohr: "I love what Palahi Paki said, which we use in one of the chapter introductions. 'Aloha is my religion. I practice it every day.' That became a theme as Sharon Linnea and I started putting stories together.

"I studied Hawaiian language and chanting with Kumu John Lake at the UH Hawaiian Studies department, and got to know Kanalu Young, another professor there, and realized that this all-embracing kindness and reaching out that that Hawaiians do to strangers is so different from what happens anywhere else. I loved that and it seemed so in keeping with what *Chicken Soup* is about."

Both UH professors contribute chapters to *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii.*

"It's like Tony Vericella says in his chapter *Land of Hospitality*," Rohr adds. "This is the one place in the world that has no ethnic majority, and it makes me feel that world peace is possible. Is life imperfect? Of course, we're just humans muddling along. But life is really extraordinary here, how the races mix and meet and share. This is the model.

"When President Kennedy came here in 1963, he said 'These islands represent all that we are and all that we can hope to be.' And his wife Jackie said 'I now know what the aloha spirit means. I hope it's contagious, for it could change the world.'"

Rohr and her considerable cast of contributors share that sentiment. They've created, as the book's subtitle puts it: "Stories of Aloha to Create Paradise Wherever You Are."

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Rohr, "a girl who came here for three weeks and stayed for 25 years and counting," is adamant in a *MidWeek* interview that she remain in the background and the focus be on those who wrote the chapters and the kupuna who inspired her. We'll get to them. Fact is, *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* would not have happened without her vision, determination and belief in the power of Hawaii.

She grew up Robin Stephens in Los Angeles. Her father, an Argentinean of native Indian and English ancestry, died when she was 4. She inherited his fascination of words:

"My father so loved languages and words. He made money putting himself through Berkeley by asking his fraternity brothers to give him 10 words out of the dictionary. If he could give the definitions, then put them together in one long, elegant sentence they had to pay him $10. If he couldn't he had to pay them, and $10 was big money at that time."

When he passed away, her mother went to work and became one of the first women employed as an engineer in America's aerospace industry, and young Robin and her brother were raised largely by their maternal grandmother.

"She was a 5 foot 10 Irish redhead who I admired so much," Rohr says. "When she turned 100, the governors of Hawaii and California paid tribute to her because she was still working 40 hours a week. She made beautiful clothes for premature babies and beautiful dolls that we gave out through HUGS here and in L.A. Her name was Elizabeth Brooks, Granny Brooks. With TV cameras documenting this celebration, one of the journalists from CNN asked for her secret to long life. She said, 'Live in gratitude. Keep a sense of humor. And in the world of human relationships, when at all possible, learn to overlook.'"

An influential family friend was Hannibal Coons, "a writer who did the *Dear George* series for the *Saturday Evening Post* in the '50s, then lots of comedy shows in Hollywood, like *Dennis the Menace*, and produced the *Kids Say The Darndest Things* books with Art Linkletter. My love of storytelling began at an early age.

"I often tell my husband" — Thos. Rohr, president of the Big Island's Waikoloa Land Co. and who developed Maui's Kapalua Resort in the 1970s — "I think that's why I fell in love with him, he has this incredible gift of language and communication.

"Plus I love his philosophy, which he and Clint Eastwood once saw on a sign in a restaurant and adopted: 'Life is uncertain — eat dessert first.'"

In Hawaii, she's worked as a commercial photographer, earned a master's degree in psychology, co-founded Riches jewelry boutique in Kahala Mall with Lo Kaimuloa, and sold real estate. For years she organized weeklong Hawaiian experiences for friends. When her future husband first asked her out — to see the Bolshoi Ballet — she said she'd love to, but she and 18 friends would be paddling the north shore of Molokai, dancing hula under the full moon, showering under 2,000-foot waterfalls and camping in caves.

When they did at last go out, she admits, "I fell in love with him in the first hour."

He says his role in *Chicken Soup from the Soul of Hawaii* was "cheering her on

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